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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): Groups Based On Kinship

John, another Mujika man, complained that his classificatory brother David 'is not my own relative. He is only of my clan.' A bystander asked how this could be and John replied, 'I say this because he does not help me in the field or with any other work. He wanders from village to village. He has no wife, but when he comes to live with me he does not help with the work. Therefore I say he is not my relative. He who does not help me is not my relative. If he is sued, I will not help him because he does not help me.' The bystander commented, 'You say this because David is poor. If he were rich, you would not say it. If he were a good man, you would not say it.' John agreed, 'Yes, if he were a good man, I would not talk like this.' Then his son spoke up, 'My father cannot say that David is not his own kinsman. Why, when one of David's brothers died, my father was the one who did the purification!'

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Here we find what is probably the basic Tonga formulation: those who help one another in a particular fashion are relatives, and those who do not so help one another are to be considered unrelated. Matrilineal groups may therefore break apart either on the score of distance or on the score of personal differences. So long as the memory of the former alliance persists, it is possible for people to re-establish their common membership within a single group. Where two bodies of kindred have evolved, the split is likely to remain permanent. Then people say, 'Once we were one. Now it looks as though we are different.'

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To maintain the ties of kinship, it is not necessary for all, or even the major portion of a group, to remain in close proximity with one another. The Tonga have never believed that kinsmen should live together in a single village, or

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even within a single neighbourhood. There are geographical limits beyond which co-operation becomes impossible but within these limits kinsmen are free to disperse without detriment to their common solidarity. Indeed, the frequency of localized droughts accompanied by local crop failures turns the dispersal of kindred into an asset rather than a liability, for each person is provided with a claim on food produced in other localities. When a hunger year strikes,  21 those with money or goods for exchange can buy food if they can find people with a surplus. Those without resources can depend only upon their personal claims upon others. They can beg from kinsmen with the expectation that they will be fed so long as there is food to be divided. In the past, they could approach fellow clansmen or clan joking-partners, though with less assurance of support. Failing these, their only resource once lay in selling themselves or some child into slavery in return for grain. Today the Administration arranges for the importation and subsidized sale of grain in times of general famine, but in a hunger year people still walk many miles to beg from kinsmen living in villages where there is some hope of finding food. These may grumble, but so long as anything remains in their granaries or they have funds with which to purchase grain, they are likely to divide with their indigent relatives, knowing that another year may reduce them to the same straits.

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